GREEN SKILLS NOW

Deliverable 3.1 – Institutional needs assessment of Fundación Colombia Incluyente

Date: 31-08-2025



Servicio Ecuatoriano de Capacitación Profesional

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Lead partner of the deliverable	CINOP
Main Authors	Fleur Hendriks - CINOP Epke Vogel - CINOP
Objective of the workpackage	To improve demand-driven interventions and innovative green inclusive education in VET, by strengthening capacities of vocational training providers capacities and VET operations
Short description of the deliverable	Report with findings and recommendations for VET providers in Ecuador and Colombia that relate to mainstreaming environmental sustainability
Link to deliverable (if any)	n.a
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Self reflection on the deliverable from the point of view of the consortium
Deviations compared to the proposal:
In order to optimize the collection of information and better address specific context of the two VET providers in Colombia and Ecuador, the approach has been somewhat extended as compared to the proposal. For this reason, we have requested an extension of the due date of this deliverable 3.1. However, due to challenges and solutions explained below. The current version is a draft version, covering the needs assessment of Colombia Incluyente.
Strong elements of the deliverable:
The needs assessment has taken a strongly participatory approach that was tailored to the specific context and needs of the VET providers in Colombia and in Ecuador. It consisted of various types of assessment tools, including interviews, online surveys and analysis of websites and documents provided by the partners.
Challenges and solutions:
SECAP is a large national educational institution that must go through lengthy procedures to organise such a needs assessment involving many staff members. Therefore, the current version of the report described the outcomes of the needs assessment for Colombia Incluyente. The SECAP needs assessment report will be added to the final version thay will be submitted no later than 18 September.
Sustainability and impact:
The needs assessment provides a thorough and participatory analysis of the current situation, challenges and capacity needs for mainstreaming environmental sustainability in the partner VET providers in Latin America, and in particular, in providing young people with the necessary green skills. Recommendations include both partner and country specific as well as more general recommendations for mainstreaming environmental sustainability that can be applicable worldwide. This forms a strong basis for long term planning and implememntation of institutional strategies and measures to equip youth with the skills needed to participate in the green economy, promoting decent employment, gender equality, and environmental sustainability.

Note: Letters of consent have been requested from the individuals appearing in the photographs included in this report. This step has been taken to ensure compliance with ethical standards and to respect the privacy and rights of all persons depicted.

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1 Introduction

The Green Skills NOW! project is an initiative funded by the European Union that seeks to contribute to sustainable development in Ecuador and Colombia by strengthening vocational education and training (VET) with an inclusive and ecological approach. Its main purpose is to develop and implement an inclusive green skills curriculum at the two local partners: Colombia Incluyente (Colombia) and SECAP (Ecuador). In addition, the project trains teaching staff and strengthens institutional capacities at both organizations to train young people, especially women, in the skills needed to participate in the green economy, promoting decent employment, gender equality, and environmental sustainability.

This needs assessment is part of Work Package three of the project: Capacity building on inclusive innovative environmental education and environmental sustainability in VET operations. The objectives of the needs assessment are to: (a) To identify the challenges and opportunities of local VET providers to mainstream environmental sustainability at organizational level, and (b) To identify the challenges and opportunities to integrate environmental education in their curriculum.

2 Methodology

The data were collected through online interviews and digital surveys and targeted various stakeholder groups, including (1) management staff, (2) curriculum coordinators and pedagogical staff, and (3) teachers. In addition to the interviews and surveys, some documentation was received and analysed related the Applus+ Capacity Building and Certification: a guided process aiming at strengthen the capabilities of Fundación Colombia Incluyente to implement sustainable practices aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). One of the documents used for this needs assessment is a summary of this process called 'Organizational Mentoring in Sustainable Development Goals'.

As the two local project partners in Ecuador and Colombia are quite different in nature, structure and national scope, we have agreed with these partners a separate data collection method that fits their context. Below, we briefly summarise the approach taken for Colombia Incluyente:

In agreement with the management of Colombia Incluyente and Plan Interntional Colombia, Three stakeholder groups were involved in the assessment:

1. **Management Team**: An online interview was conducted with four members of the management team from Colombia Incluyente, moderated by representatives from CINOP and Plan Colombia. Similar to the coordinators and pedagogical staff, the management team responded to a structured questionnaire during the interview, which was later submitted to CINOP. The questionnaire included open-ended and multiple-choice questions.
2. **Curriculum Coordinators and Pedagogical Staff**: Data was collected through an online interview guided by a structured questionnaire. The interview was attended by curriculum and pedagogical staff from Colombia Incluyente, with two moderators from CINOP and Plan Colombia. Following the interview, a completed version of the questionnaire was submitted to CINOP for analysis. The questionnaire included both open-ended and multiple-choice questions.
3. **Teachers:** An online survey was distributed via Microsoft Forms and completed by eight (8) teachers. The survey included both open-ended and multiple-choice questions, allowing for both qualitative and quantitative analysis.

All data collected was analyzed by CINOP, using a thematic and comparative approach to identify key patterns and areas of need across both organizations.

3 Summary of the initial baseline analysis from the project plan

The proposal of the Green Skills Now project already included a needs analysis for the partners in Colombia and Ecuador and we provide here below a brief summary of the initial baseline analysis for Colombia Incluyente that was conducted between December 2023 and February 2024.

1. Need for a gender transformative approach: Colombia Incluyente (CI) recognises significant gender gaps in training for employment and employability, emphasizing the need for skills and strategies that address these disparities. Adopting a gender transformative approach advocated by Plan Colombia is deemed essential to deliver VET that responds to gender-specific needs, challenges social norms.

2. Need for soft skills: related to the needs analysis on gender, CI has found the Colombian VET context requires all trainings to include soft skills related to civic engagement, participation, self-determination, and leadership. Within the sphere of green skills, such soft skills are required to implement the values such as responsibility and solidarity needed for the implementation of concrete actions involved in care of the environment.

3. Access to basic needs: One of the greatest difficulties VET providers in Barranquilla, such as CI, encounter is their student's lack of access to basic needs, which prevents the development of the activities of the training centre. This lack of access to basic needs leads to a high dropout rate.

4. Appropriate measures to prevent the high dropout rate: While basic needs deficit impact retention, so do other factors. Mental health problems, emotional instability, addictions, and lack of hope, all lead young people to make mistakes and, above all, to enter informal jobs.
5. Better access to content: Technological limitations, lack of connectivity, and economic difficulties have been a major obstacle in allowing youth to have access to new content or to partake in VET offerings in person or online.

6. Overcoming training gaps: Colombia lacks education and training on topics such as digital skills, environment, green skills, mental health, psychosocial support. Training and preparation in green skills needs to be strengthened in light of global dynamics and the interests of companies and employers.

Considering the aforementioned factors, the importance of a needs-based approach for VET institutions cannot be overstated. It involves understanding and addressing the specific requirements and challenges faced by learners to tailor programmes and methodologies effectively.

4 Findings of the needs assessment

4.1 Context, challenges and needs Colombia Incluyente

Fundación Colombia Incluyente is a private non-profit organization with +10 years of experience whose purpose is to support the construction of a Country of Peace, with a focus on Inclusion and Diversity and Environmental Sustainability. The organisation is located in Barranquilla.
The organisation has identified the following mission for the period 2023-2025:

- Consolidate the position as the No. 1 operator nationwide in the implementation and execution of Labour Inclusion Routes with a Focus on Closing Gaps under the Pay-for-Results Methodology.
- Become the first Implementer of Labour Inclusion Routes with Quality Certification in all its processes.
- Promote the strengthening of green skills through our MANGLAR Environmental Training School.
- Create a Centre for Innovation and Digital Content Creation in partnership with "Gente Estratégica Centro de Formación para el Trabajo" to promote digital skills training and support Industry 4.0.

Strategic vision and institutional commitment related to environmental sustainability
According to the management team, environmental sustainability is integrated into the mission, vision and institutional policy of Fundación Colombia Incluyente.

Mission: *"We are dedicated to building a peaceful country where inclusion, diversity, and environmental sustainability are fundamental pillars."*

Vision: *"We will establish ourselves as the number one national operator in the implementation and execution of labor inclusion routes with a gap-closing approach under a results-based payment methodology. We will become the leading implementer of these routes, promote the strengthening of green skills through our environmental training school Manglar, and create a center for innovation and digital content creation in alliance with strategic partners."*

As mentioned above, CI is in the process of guided implementation and certification related to *Capacity Building for Sustainability and Contribution to the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).* Hence, the ultimate goal is to obtain '**Applus+ Certification'** for its contribution to the UN Sustainable Development Goals. This process is supported by the certification body Applus+ and seeks to train CI in the application of sustainable practices through the acquisition of knowledge, the development of effective strategies, and the measurement of their impact. The staff members of CI have received training during the certification process and got their personal certification in July 2025. The certification for Colombia Incluyente, as the organization, is expected in September 2025.

The specific objectives of the certification process are:

- Acquire fundamental knowledge about sustainability and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) relevant to the foundation's operations.
- Understand the principles and conceptual frameworks of corporate sustainability and its alignment with the SDGs.
- Identify and analyse the three SDGs most relevant to the organisation's management, as well as their impact on the community.

- Explore best practices in governance. Establishment of effective governance structures that promote transparency. Training will be provided on creating a framework that ensures decisions are aligned with sustainability principles and the SDGs.
- Recognise the importance of strategic alliances and stakeholder engagement in the implementation of the SDGs. Possible partners inside and outside the sector will be identified, as well as ways of collaborating on initiatives that strengthen collective impact.
- Develop effective communication skills to report on the foundation's commitment to the SDGs.
- Prepare to obtain Applus+ Certification, recognising the foundation's contribution to the SDGs.

The specific steps and activities of the Applus+ certification process are added in Annex I.

Another initiative of CI is the creation of the **Manglar Environmental Training School**, through which the institution commits itself to sustainability by training students and (vulnerable) communities in green skills to become active agents of transformation. In this way, the organisation promotes environmental awareness and participation in the protection of Colombia's natural resources, as well as the adoption of sustainable practices, ensuring a green legacy for future generations. CI is dedicated to promoting the circular economy in vulnerable communities, with a focus on responsible resource management, waste reduction and minimising environmental impact. This process aims to opens doors to sustainable entrepreneurship and to creating employment opportunities in a more resilient economy.

In the framework of this Manglar intitiative, CI has developed a basic training module called "**Tejiendo Verde**" on green competences for all students. The main goal of the new module is to raise awareness and promote behavioural change. More information on this is provided in the "Curriculum" part of this analysis.

Even though the organization has formally integrated sustainability, most teachers (6 out of 8) indicate that the institution is in a design phase regarding environmental sustainability. It is said that there is a lack of **institutional policies and guidelines** for integrating sustainability in education. Therefore, formal ambitions need to be developed for the organization to further integrate sustainability in the organization as a whole. An interview with the sustainability coordinator has revealed that there is a need to expand the vision and ambitions regarding a sustainable infrastructure to become a **green campus**. Moreover, while some teachers mentioned **time and resources** are being made available by the institutional level (such as during team meetings and workshops), others noted the lack of formal or consistent time and space made available to integrate or develop sustainability initiatives.

Leadership and coordination

According to the management team, sustainability is managed by a team responsible for it. However, it is not managed through a single unit, but rather as a cross-cutting axis present in all areas of the organization. There reason to do so is: "While there are individuals who lead this component, sustainability is not seen as an isolated function, but as a shared and cross-cutting commitment that runs through all processes, decisions, and organizational structures." The different areas (training, technical and executive) differ in their responsibilities regarding the development and implementation of environmental initiatives:

- **Training area**: *"there is a team in charge of developing curricula, materials, and products focused on green skills, which are integrated into programmes aimed at both students and companies."*
- **Technical area**: *"professionals are responsible for continually reinforcing and applying environmental principles and practices in their day-to-day work."*

- **Governance level**: *"sustainability is led from the presidency itself, with a coordinating team composed of [three staff members], who serve as key points of reference and facilitators of this approach throughout the institution."*

Nevertheless, leadership and coordination of sustainability initiatives are experienced differently by teachers. According to them, there seems to be a lack of dedicated sustainability committees or leadership. Even though some teachers recognize there are sustainability groups and people with responsibilities associated with sustainability projects, responses suggest work is done "across all areas," but without structured leadership roles or coordination mechanisms. On the other hand, some teachers do not know of any groups, committees, or task forces related to sustainability within the institution.

After interviewing the teachers, management team and curriculum coordinators, an additional interview with the (now) sustainability coordinator revealed that she (in August 2025) received the role as **coordinator of the sustainability theme**. This shows that the organization is, as part of the Applus+ certification process, formalizing and expanding their sustainability practices.

Infrastructure and operations
According to the management team as well as teachers, sustainability is integrated in the physical environment through:

- **Waste management practices**: recycling bins are being used for waste separation and responsible disposal of waste.
- **Efficient energy use**: CI aims to transition towards sustainable energy use that reduce its environmental footprint and is, therefore, in an evaluation phase for the installation of solar panels.
- **Water conservation**: responsible water use and conservation practices are promoted by the organization.
- **Digitalization**: technological platforms are used to reduce paper usage across all of administrative, training and operational processes, contributing to more ecological and efficient management.

To support sustainability initiatives, financial resources come primarily from these two sources:
1. The own budget from Foundation Colombia Incluyente
2. Contributions from strategic partners involved in the projects

As mentioned before, according to the sustainability coordinator, there is a need for developing a clear vision and ambitions in regards to making the operations and infrastructure of CI more sustainable to contribute to the organization having a **green campus**.

Stakeholder engagement
Over four years ago, Colombia Incluyente developed a strategic partnership with a Spanish multinational company (based in Barcelona) specialized in sustainability. The aim of the partnership was to develop the **Carbon Neutrality Route** which has been launched three years ago. The aim of this route is to raise awareness among companies in Colombia's Caribbean region about the need to adopt measures to mitigate global warming and climate change. In collaboration with the Chambers of Commerce of Barranquilla and Cartagena, this route includes three training programmes for companies which address topics such as carbon footprint measurement, climate change mitigation strategies, and the promotion

of ecological and sustainable behaviours within the business environment. Over 60 companies have followed this training programme.

Besides this, Colombia Incluyente applies an "inter-institutional coordination approach" with several actors from public and private sectors to work on themes such as social inclusion, labour inclusion, income generation for vulnerable populations, and also sustainability and climate change. The stakeholders include:

- International cooperation agencies
- Foreign governments and the Colombian government
- National and international NGOs
- Business associations
- Private sector companies in Colombia

When it comes to the region of Barranquilla, there are no formal mechanisms or platforms to coordinate actors regarding sustainability. The existing initiatives in vocational training and the labour market are fragmentated among actors and lack coordination, planning and monitoring. Moreover, the organization also sees a lack of awareness among stakeholder groups about environmental sustainability and how the theme is connected to the organizations.

According to teachers, the external environment of the school is integrated in the sustainability practices and initiatives. For instance, there are partnerships with NGOs and governmental organizations to strengthen sustainability projects. Further, students and parents are involved in community participation by events such as clean-up days, planting, or environmental workshops.

Student engagement

According to the management team and teachers, students are involved in environmental activities with the aim to raise awareness. Examples are topics like "waste management, beach cleanups, tree planting and home gardens." These initiatives demonstrate a commitment to sustainability. Such activities are promoted through the programme called Life Influencer in which students are challenged to become ambassadors in their communities for environmental issues.

Curriculum

The integration of sustainability in the curriculum is done through the programme *Tejiendo Verde: Green Skills for a Sustainable Life*. This program is introduced in 2024 and by August 2025, 2803 students (all female as it is part of a program for women) have been trained by it. This training is part of a larger program in which there is a focus on social skills (taught by a teacher during a webinar) and green skills (taught through an online program with a virtual teacher). The green skills curriculum covers 10 study hours and is described as having an introductory scope. The curriculum introduces learners to foundational topics such as climate change, pollution, natural hazards, sustainable lifestyles, and green jobs. Moreover, the aim is to raise awareness and provide basic knowledge that prepares learners to continue toward more technical or specialized pathways. This presents both a strength and a limitation: while it serves as an accessible starting point, there is a clear need to deepen, specialize, and contextualize the content for greater educational impact.

Accordingly, the management team wants to "lead to deeper knowledge, the development of sector-specific curricula, and effective training of individuals in green skills so they can take on roles in the formal labour market." There is a wish to shift towards in-depth training supported by solid educational tools. Key topics are, for instance, the circular economy and water resource management.

Teachers expressed the need for updated and contextualized teaching materials in order to integrate sustainability in their teaching (in contribution to the Tejiendo Verde programme). Reasons for this include outdated official curricula, rigid academic structures, and limited space in existing programmes to include sustainability content. Furthermore, a recurring theme was the disconnection between theoretical sustainability concepts and their practical implementation, making it an abstract concept not being adapted to the reality of the students.

Additionally, one teacher mentioned *"Assessment is focused on traditional academic results. Assessment systems tend to focus on theoretical knowledge rather than sustainable skills or attitudes. This can discourage teachers from including practical, collaborative, or socially impactful activities."*

Also curriculum coordinators and pedagogical staff identified multiple challenges related to the effective implementation of environmental topics in the curriculum:

- **Gaps in prior knowledge among students**: many students have limited knowledge which means that teachers have to start at a very basic level to build meaningful understanding.
- **Students miss to see the relevance to their realities as the programme is abstract and disconnected to their day-to-day lives**. This seems to hinder motivation and perceived importance of the themes.
- In communities with **challenging access to immediate needs** (such as income or basic services), sustainability and climate change issues are viewed as less urgent. Therefore, there is a need to integrate how sustainability relates to topics such as wellbeing, family livelihood and long-term community resilience.
- As the programme includes **general sustainability and climate change topics**, more in-dept themes should be included to increase critical thinking, promoting equity, and fostering community-based solutions.
- Also **the connection of sustainability and green jobs seems to be introductory** covering jobs for the future, ecological entrepreneurship, and self-awareness and life goals. There seems to be a need to continue expanding training content with topics that connect environmental, economic, and personal dimensions in practical and transformative ways.

Pedagogy and didactics

The existing programme **Tejiendo Verde** is an audiovisual programme taught by a created character called **Manglara**. "*Manglara is a woman responsible for transmitting knowledge and wisdom to all the students in the organization".* It is based on a participatory and reflective pedagogical approach, which includes guiding case studies, analysis of local situations, social mapping and group reflection exercises. Students have to reflect on their own environment, culture, economic context and consumption decisions. A key component of the Tejiendo Verde programme is the use of custom-designed training booklets, which serve as self-guided learning tools for students. "*These booklets include practical exercises that encourage participants to analyze their personal, community, and territorial realities, and identify concrete actions they can implement based on their specific context".* This approach aims *"to strengthen critical autonomy, promoting a culture of conscious decision-making".*

In regards to the perception of students of the programme Tejiendo Verde, the sustainability coordinator revealed that students are happy with the course and have given positive feedback.

Nevertheless, both management and teachers identify several challenges in making sustainability education meaningful and accessible. According to the management team, *"one of the foundation's biggest challenges is to create user-friendly content that enables clear understanding and promotes a*

deeper sense of shared responsibility over the long term." Teachers report that the topics taught can feel "ethereal" and "abstract", which makes it difficult to translate into engaging lessons. Therefore, they face several challenges in making sustainability education meaningful and accessible to students. Some teachers also mentioned a lack of interests in sustainability among teachers which suggest a challenge in motivation and relevance of teachers for including the theme in their teaching.

According to curriculum coordinators and pedagogical staff, there seems to be misinformation about climate change and sustainability among students. Therefore, teachers face challenges to address and correct these misconceptions in such manner as well. This requires teachers to be open, curious and encourage dialogue in the classroom. They have to listen to students interests, give room to their perspectives and together give meaning to sustainability and climate change themes.

Concerning didactics, teachers expressed the need for teaching materials and support to integrate sustainability in their lessons. They wish for lesson plans and teaching materials. Furthermore, these materials should be connected to students' realities to ensure they are not too abstract for students.

According to curriculum coordinators and pedagogical staff, challenges when teaching about sustainable lifestyles and personal behaviours include:

- ***Limited economic conditions****: Many participants recognize more sustainable practices, but are unable to adopt them due to financial constraints (e.g., organic food, eco-friendly products, alternative transport).*
- ***Unequal access to sustainable options****: In some regions, there are no real alternatives to implement eco-friendly behaviours (e.g., recycling programmes, quality public transport, clean energy), which leads to frustration and discouragement.*
- ***Resistance to changing habits****: Certain behaviours are deeply rooted culturally or generationally, so change requires time, support, and relatable role models.*
- ***Feeling that individual effort isn't enough****: It's common to hear "it won't matter if big companies don't change," which weakens personal commitment.*
- ***Overload of responsibilities for women****: Most of our participants are women who juggle multiple roles (caregivers, providers, community leaders), making it harder to adopt new sustainable habits without support networks.*

Professional development

According to the management team, the entire team participated in a training programme that was carried out over more than six months as a part of the aforementioned **Applus+ institutional certification process in the Sustainable Development Goals**. See Annex I for the sessions and activities of the Applus+ certification process. The training was concluded with an individual assessment providing each participant with a personal certification in July 2025. Even though staff have been trained, the CI sustainability coordinator highlights the need to further integrate green skills in CI's staff so it is an integrated part of everyone's work.

Regarding the confidence teachers experience to teach topics about the environment and climate change, none of the teachers have said to not feel properly prepared. Three (3) teachers are "a little confident", two are "confident" and two are "very confident". Also, no teachers have said to feel not confident teaching sustainability topics related to the field of work they teach for. Four (4) teachers are "a little confident" to do so, two (2) are "confident" and two are "very confident". Even though no teachers have said to not feel confident, there seems to be a variety in answers implying the need to increase teachers' confidence to teach sustainability themes.

Even though 7 out of 8 teachers have received training in environmental or climate education in the last two years, teachers identified a need for continuous professional development as they mentioned a lack in teacher training as "*many educators have not received specific training in sustainability or environmental education*." Issues to integrate sustainability in teaching are linked to low interest and awareness in the subject (from teachers as well as students), a resistance of change, a lack of time for training and the "*workshops offered are very basic*". To develop their skills, teachers would welcome workshops or short courses, online courses or webinars, and teaching materials and lessons plans.

Some teachers report that there are opportunities to share best practices and apply lessons learned during team meetings, pedagogical workshops, committees, and other teacher training spaces. However, teachers also indicate that there is currently no formal or consistent time and space dedicated to these activities.

Gender and inclusion

Colombia Incluyente specifically aims to promote the active participation of young women in technical training programmes by, for instance, providing access to training in green skills, applying a gender and youth perspective in programmes and applying a women's empowerment component in training routes. According to the management team, however, "*it is necessary to deepen, expand, and diversify the actions we are currently implementing*." Specific needs presented by the management team are:

- "*Updated gender-sensitive methodologies adapted to different social contexts and population groups*."
- "*Expanded curricula that structurally integrate a gender perspective into technical and socio-environmental competencies*."
- "*International exchange of experiences to adopt best practices and adapt successful models to our local realities*."
- *"Additional financial resources to scale existing programmes and reach a larger number of women beneficiaries*."

In addition, the management team stresses the need to strengthen institutional capacities, including the development of knowledge, methodologies, certifications, technical teams, and internal training processes.

From the perspective of teachers, a **gender and community perspective** is applied in the Tejiendo Verde programme. Curriculum coordinators and pedagogical staff confirm that elements of gender and inclusion are present, but note that the programme lacks an in-depth approach to gender differences in the context of sustainability and climate change.

When it comes to gender differences in sustainable and green jobs, the Tejiendo Verde programme includes activities and exercises that encourage women to work in sustainable and green sectors. Some issues regarding this remain: stereotypes associated with green jobs, lack of female role models in these fields, gaps in access to technical and digital training, unpaid care burdens that limit women's availability and energy, and, fear of not being taken seriously in traditionally male-dominated spaces.

5 Conclusions and recommendations

5.1 Conclusions and recommendations Colombia Incluyente

Strategic Vision and Institutional Commitment
The findings reveal that Colombia Incluyente has made significant progress in positioning sustainability as a core value, particularly at the strategic and programme levels. For instance, initiatives such as the capacity building (trough Applus+ training of staff at teaching, technical and governance levels) and certification on Sustainability and Contribution to the SDGs, Tejiendo Verde and the Carbon Neutrality Route reflect a clear institutional commitment to this theme.

Moreover, according to the management team, environmental sustainability is integrated into the institution's mission, vision, and policy framework. Nevertheless, the **vision and mission** do not provide concrete goals to give direction to more sustainability in the future of Colombia Incluyente. The formal mission provides intentions in regard to sustainability but does not link this with education and the desired contribution of the institution towards sustainability. According to the Whole School Approach[1], a vision is, on the one hand, about the responsibility as an educational organization towards students and their development as human beings, citizens, and professionals. On the other hand, it concerns the responsibility we, as an organization, wish to take for one another and for the planet, while connecting to the societal context of our time. Hence, it is recommended to revise the vision to:

- Explicitly state what students should learn and become (human beings, citizens, professionals) and why this matters.
- Broaden the sustainability dimension beyond green skills to include social and ecological responsibility.
- Define the intended long-term impact on learners and society, making the vision more future-oriented and inspiring.

To integrate sustainability in education, the Green Thread[2] highlights the need to develop **ambitions** to translate the vision and mission to concrete actions. The ambitions should be feasible, practical, affordable and organisable. As Colombia Incluyente aims to making their operations and infrastructure more sustainable to work towards a green campus and to increase the green skills of their entire staff, they should (besides developing a clear vision on this) translate these goals to concrete ambitions. This provides a clear framework of which actions should be undertaken, who should do the work and when actions should be undertaken.

Despite having a vision and strategy, **perceptions and experiences** across organizational levels vary, especially among teachers, curriculum coordinators and pedagogical staff. While the management team describes sustainability as a theme embedded in all departments, teachers report a lack of formal leadership structures, committees, or clear coordination mechanisms. This disconnect highlights a gap between institutional ambition and its implementation across staff levels. Therefore, it is recommended to:

- Clearly communicate institutional sustainability vision and mission across the organization and to all internal and external stakeholders to foster a shared understanding and create visibility. This could include regular updates, storytelling about sustainability initiatives, and the integration of sustainability messaging into meetings, newsletters, and public-facing materials.

[1] Whole School Appraoch: https://wholeschoolapproach.lerenvoormorgen.org/over-de-wsa#section2
[2] The Green Thread (De Groene Draad) is a tool developed in The Netherlands that provide educational teams with practical tools for integrating sustainability in education. https://lerenvoormorgen.org/en/artikelen/de-groene-draad/

By doing so, the institution can foster a shared understanding, build engagement, and create a sense of ownership among staff, bridging the gap between strategic ambition and everyday practice.

Leadership and coordination

The analysis of leadership and coordination of sustainability initiatives reveals a gap between management's perception and the experiences of teachers. While the management team emphasizes a cross-cutting approach (embedding sustainability across all areas rather than within a single unit) teachers report limited visibility of these efforts and a lack of structured leadership. Some teachers acknowledge the existence of sustainability groups or individuals responsible for environmental initiatives, but these efforts appear fragmented, uncoordinated, or even unknown. This disconnect highlights the challenge of translating institutional level commitments into clearly perceived leadership and coordination practices.

Recommendations for strengthening leadership and coordination in regard to sustainability:

- Even though groups, committees, and tasks forces related to sustainability do exist, this is fragmentated throughout the organization without it being coordinated and with some teachers not knowing of the existence of them. Therefore, a recommendation is to strengthen the coordination of sustainability groups and initiatives in the organization. Examples are: establishment of clearer formal structures, defined leadership roles, and transparent responsibilities.
- As an additional interview revealed that in August 2025 a sustainability coordinator has been appointed, it is important to clearly communicate this to the organization to reduce the experiences of it being fragmented, uncoordinated and unknown.
- Identify which outcomes of the Applus+ capacity building and certification (entregables/herramientas Annex I) relate to the SDG on environmental sustainability and discuss whether this requires a separate roadmap for mainstreaming environmental sustainability in the organisation in order to increase coordination of sustainability initiatives.
- Plan active communication among staff, (future) students and external stakeholders about policies, strategies, measures and actions that promote environmental sustainability and the development of green skills within the organisation and actively invite people to engage and bring in new ideas (see also item 5 in Annex I).
- By making sustainability leadership more visible and structured, the institution can bridge the gap between its strategic ambitions and practical implementation, fostering a coherent and shared commitment to environmental goals across all organizational levels.

Infrastructure and operations

According to the Whole School Approach[3], the physical environment (such as buildings, infrastructure and operations) can contribute to a sustainable learning environment. A key questions to consider is how the physical environment of the school can be an inspiring place to learn? It is important to communicate choices in making infrastructure and operations more sustainable to make efforts visible for students, staff and (external) stakeholders. This contributes to them feeling more engaged in making the physical environment more sustainable.

To make the infrastructure and operations of Colombia Incluyente more sustainable, it is recommended to:

[3] Whole School Approach – Building and operations: https://wholeschoolapproach.lerenvoormorgen.org/over-de-wsa#section6

- As mentioned in *Strategic Vision and Institutional Commitment*, there should be a clear mission, vision and ambition in regard to the infrastructure and operations goals of CI. Only when it is clear what the goals of the organizations are, concrete actions and target areas can be developed in order to work towards these goals, with a clear time path in place.
- Assess together with facility management staff and the environmental sustainability team the current measures described in chapter 4 related to waste management (including recycling activities), efficient energy use, water conservation and digitalization, as well as the impact of these measures. Consider how these practices contribute to a sustainable learning environment and how they can be expanded to work towards a green campus.
- Describe how students and teachers, but also external stakeholders can support in the planning, implementation and monitoring of these measures and actions.
- Plan the identification and mobilisation of additional financial resources for these measures (such as the solar panels CI intends to install). These can come amongst others from private sector and from national, regional or local subsidies.

Stakeholder engagement

Although there is collaboration with the external environment on the institutional level, strengthen community engagement and foster a culture of participation by engaging students, teachers, and external partners (e.g., NGOs) in co-creating sustainability projects. Actions could be identified that contribute to or link up to the plans of CI related to the Applus+ certification's specific objective *"Reconocer la importancia de las alianzas estratégicas y la participación de las partes interesadas en la implementación de los ODS".*

Specific actions the could include:

- Conduct a stakeholder mapping and identify roles and values that are linked to the environmental sustainability objectives of CI (related or in addition to item 4 in Annex I).
- Establish a structural external stakeholder working group on environmental sustainability.
- Jointly develop a roadmap for joint objectives and actions.

Curriculum

In terms of curriculum, the programme Tejiendo Verde offers a short introduction in environmental education, but it remains abstract and doesn't offer in-depth sustainability and climate change education. Furthermore, teachers, curriculum coordinators and pedagogical staff point to theoretical content not sufficiently connected to students' lived realities, making it difficult to generate motivation and deeper learning.

Recommendations for curriculum improvement:

- Conduct together with CINOP and Txorierri experts an in-depth gap analysis of the Teijido Verde programme in order to identify what opportunities for strengthening and deepening the curriculum can be found. The planned Masterclass on environmental education in the EU (task 3.3) by Txorierri can also be used for this purpose.
- Use the existing Green Life Skills curriculum of Plan International to improve the current Teijiendo Verde programme and create a more in-depth and elaborated curriculum to move from basic climate change understanding themes aimed at raising awareness. Moreover, ensure that all content is contextualized and connected to students by reflecting their realities, their environment and vocational pathways.

- Analyse relevance and added value of additional tools and instruments such as the European Sustainability Competence Framework (GreenComp), the Green Thread and the Whole School Approach.
- Agree on the size (in nr. of study hours) and exact scope of the envisaged programme in order to bring it in line with the overall vocational training offer of CI and with the ambitions of the organisation related to green skills development among the students.

Curriculum Coordinators and Pedagogical Staff suggest to integrate the following themes to deepen students' knowledge and engagement:

- Climate justice and human rights: To explore how climate change disproportionately affects certain populations—especially women, rural communities, and migrants.
- Local solutions and community resilience: Sharing territorial examples of collective action to show how adaptation, resistance, and regeneration are possible.
- Ecofeminism and gender perspectives in sustainability: Addressing the connections between gender, care work, and environmental protection, and highlighting the leadership of women in climate action.
- Climate change adaptation: Beyond understanding the problem, it's vital to strengthen people's capacity to anticipate, adjust, and coexist with its effects in everyday life.
- Territories and ancestral knowledge: Incorporating Indigenous and Afro-descendant worldviews on nature and ecological balance as part of an intercultural learning approach.
- Personal eco-finance: Teaching how economic decisions (savings, spending, investment) have environmental implications, and how sustainability can align with household management.
- Sustainable food and food sovereignty: Promoting more responsible diets (less processed food, more local production), while highlighting practices like urban gardens, food swaps, and mindful cooking.
- Sustainable fashion and critical clothing consumption: Addressing the environmental impact of fast fashion and encouraging alternatives like clothing swaps, repair, and ethical design.
- Conscious mobility: Encouraging reflection on transportation choices, and promoting walking, cycling, carpooling, or remote work as sustainable options.
- Eco-friendly self-care: Incorporating practices like natural cosmetics, plastic-free hygiene, responsible water use, and body care approaches that also respect the planet.
- Green financial literacy: teaching how to make environmentally responsible economic decisions, both in personal life and business ventures.
- Partnerships and collaborative networks: encouraging associative work, cooperativism, and mutual support networks among community-based green initiatives.
- Emotional intelligence for environmental leadership: building emotional management, resilience, and self-care as essential skills for working in or leading sustainable sectors.
- Designing circular business models: offering tools to help structure business ideas based on circular economy principles.
- Digitalization and sustainability: exploring how digital tools can support green innovation, eco-marketing, and access to broader markets.
- In communities with challenging access to immediate needs (such as income or basic services), sustainability and climate change issues are viewed as less urgent. Therefore, there is a need to integrate how sustainability relates to topics such as wellbeing, family livelihood and long-term community resilience.

Pedagogy and didactics

The pedagogical approach used in Tejiendo Verde is participatory and reflective, supported by learning tools such as booklets and local case studies. However, challenges persist in addressing misconceptions about climate change, and in creating materials that are accessible, context-specific, and engaging for students.

Hence, recommendations for strengthening pedagogy and didactics are:

- Continue investing in participatory, interactive, practice based, and reflective learning methods that help to bring abstract sustainability concepts to life and connect them with students' realities. Those should also be focused on addressing challenges related to motivation, access, and conceptual clarity.
- Establish common pedagogical guidelines to help teachers design and deliver sustainability content in a structured and student-centered way. This should be focused on encouraging curiosity, openness, and shared meaning-making with students.
- Promote the sharing of effective lesson plans and methods within and across teams.

Professional development

When it comes to professional development, there is variation in teachers' confidence levels for integrating sustainability in their lessons. While most have received some form of training in regard to sustainability, they report a lack of depth, relevance, and ongoing support and learning opportunities. There is also limited dedicated time or space within the institution to develop or apply sustainability-related knowledge and skills.

Recommendations for professional development:

- Offer regular, in-depth teacher training on sustainability. Even though all staff members have conducted the Applus+ training, teachers should receive more in-depth training on sustainability content teaching strategies, contextual knowledge and interdisciplinary approaches. This should be in line with the sustainability and climate change themes that will be added to the programmes.
- Besides increasing knowledge on sustainability and climate change themes. The organisation has the desire to increase the green skills of its staff. It is believed that all jobs in the organisation can include green skills and, hence, everyone should receive training on how green skills are part of their jobs and how their roles can contribute to a more sustainable institution and learning environment.
- Address teacher-identified needs such as time constraints, lack of incentives, and low confidence through providing them with resources (such as time) and in-depth training.
- Create formal opportunities for teachers peer learning to reflect, exchange ideas, and co-develop new practices (e.g., during team meetings or internal workshops). By doing so, ensure that professional development is practical, job-relevant, and ongoing, not limited to one-off sessions.

Gender and inclusion

There is an emerging understanding across all studied groups that sustainability education must better incorporate gender-sensitive methodologies. While elements of gender are present in current curricula, there is no comprehensive or structural integration. Persistent barriers such as stereotypes, lack of role models, and unequal access to training continue to affect the participation of young women in education and the access to green jobs.

Recommendations for gender and inclusion:

- Move from an incipient to a structural approach by embedding more subjects regarding gender equality and inclusion across training content.
- Develop and implement gender-sensitive learning materials and tools tailored to different social groups.
- Promote the visibility of female role models in sustainability sectors and support women's access to technical and digital training.
- Provide specialized training for teachers about themes such as ecofeminism and gender-climate justice.

6 Suggested steps for follow-up

Curriculum development

As the development or adaptation of a green skills curriculum for Colombia Incluyente is one of the cornerstones of the Green Skills Now project, we recommend that CI establishes a specific ad-hoc committee to select and prioritize among the additional themes that were identified by the Curriculum Coordinators and Pedagogical Staff during the institutional needs assessment.

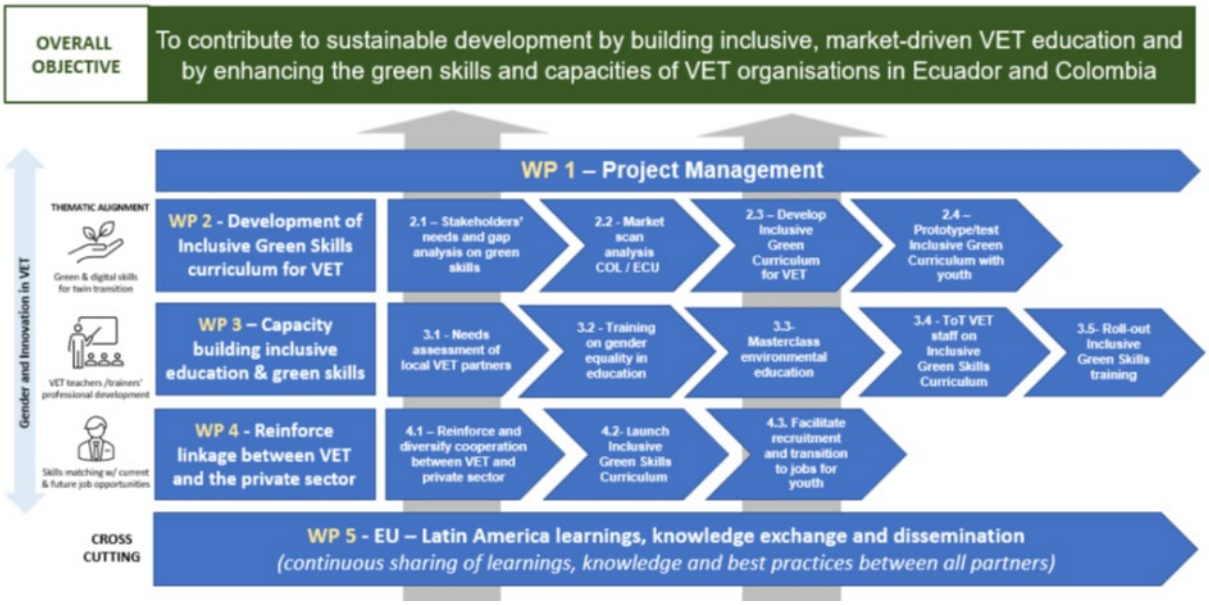
CI can use and pilot elements, learning methods and guidelines from the Plan International Green Life Skills curriculum to extend and further improve their own Tejiendo Verde programme. The above mentioned committee will make a first selection of useful elements, based on the outcomes of the current needs assessment and the skills needs analysis of work package 2. Next, the teachers/instructors of the Tejiendo Verde programme can start piloting new materials and approaches.

After the pilot and based on the agreed size and scope of the envisaged green skills programme, the project experts from CINOP and Txorierri will further support CI in adapting the curriculum for this programme to the organisation's needs (as part of work package 2).

Capacity building

This institutional needs assessment will allow the respective project partners to develop a training plan for academic staff as indicated in the figure below in the WP 3 activities, including:

Capacity building activity	Partner responsible
3.2 Training on gender equality and inclusive education	Plan Ecuador and Plan Colombia
3.3 Masterclass on environmental education in the EU	Txorierri
3.4 Train-of-Trainer) of VET partners staff on Inclusive Green Skills and innovative pedagogical methodologies	CINOP



Annex I: Sessions and activities of Applus+ certification

SESIÓN	ACTIVIDADES	HORAS	ENTREGABLE / HERRAMIENTA
1 Introducción Contexto AGENDA 2030 y ODS	- Presentación de la Agenda 2030 y los ODS específicos para la fundación- Análisis de la relevancia de los ODS para la fundación en su contexto local y nacional.	3	Presentación PowerPoint sobre los ODS y su relevancia para la fundación.
2 Identificación de impactos y cadena de valor	- Diagnóstico del impacto de los ODS en la fundación hacia las comunidades donde opera.- Identificación de actores clave en la cadena de valor relacionados con los ODS (por ejemplo, empleadores, instituciones educativas, empresas locales, globales).	5	Plantilla de diagnóstico de impactos para identificar los efectos de la fundación en los ODS.
3 Creación KPI - objetivos ODS	- Definición de indicadores específicos para medir el impacto de los ODS dentro de la fundación.- Establecimiento de metas mensuales y anuales de acuerdo con los ODS.- Herramientas para la medición y seguimiento del progreso.	5	Plantilla de KPIs adaptada a los ODS a los que apunta la fundación- Ejemplos de KPIs para cada ODS y orientación sobre cómo establecer metas alcanzables.
4 Gobernanza – Alianzas Stakeholders	- Identificación de actores clave en la gobernanza relacionada.- Estrategias para formar alianzas sostenibles y eficaces.- Definición de roles y responsabilidades dentro de las alianzas, y el impacto que pueden tener sobre los ODS.	4	Plantilla de mapeo de stakeholders para identificar actores clave en la cadena de valor.
5 Estrategia de comunicación – Evaluación	- Creación de una estrategia de comunicación que involucre a todos los stakeholders relevantes (comunicaciones internas y externas).- Definición de un plan de evaluación que permita monitorear y comunicar los avances en formación, inclusión, y empleo.	3	Creación de una estrategia de comunicación que la fundación utilizará para transmitir los avances en los ODS.

Annex II: References for further reading

GreenComp The European sustainability competence framework (European Commission)
The development of a European sustainability competence framework is one of the policy actions set out in the European Green Deal as a catalyst to promote learning on environmental sustainability in the European Union. GreenComp identifies a set of sustainability competences to feed into education programmemes to help learners develop knowledge, skills and attitudes that promote ways to think, plan and act with empathy, responsibility, and care for our planet and for public health.
Bianchi, G., Pisiotis, U. and Cabrera Giraldez, M., GreenComp The European sustainability competence framework, Punie, Y. and Bacigalupo, M. editor(s), EUR 30955 EN, Publications Office of the European Union, Luxembourg, 2022.
JRC Publications Repository - GreenComp The European sustainability competence framework

GRETA network on green vocational excellence (European Training Foundation - ETF)
Going green: GRETA | ETF (europa.eu), including the report with analyses practices and the challenges in the processes for the greening of VET and provides policy recommendations on how to advance in sustainability and green skills development: GRETA Greening of VET.pdf

Skills anticipation and VET for a greener future: Cedefop practical guide 4
Meeting skill needs for the green transition | CEDEFOP

UN organization references

UNESCO-UNEVOC promising practices
Innovative and Promising Practices (unesco.org) select Greening TVET in thematic options

UNESCO-UNEVOC centres project
Generic Green Skills TVET (greenskillsresources.com)

UNESCO-UNEVOC
Ecologizar la educación y formación técnica y profesional. Guía práctica para centros e instituciones (en español)
unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000265493/PDF/265493spa.pdf.multi

UNESCO
Education for sustainable development for 2030 toolbox | UNESCO

UNESCO
Green school quality standard (2024)

Greening TVET and skills development: a practical guidance tool. International Labour Organisation (2022)
This tool supports TVET stakeholders to mainstream skills for the green transition in TVET and skills development in a systemic and holistic manner. It provides "how-to" guidance on designing competency standards and curricula for greener jobs, adapting training delivery and assessments to support greener learning, adapting practices to maintain a greener campus, capacitating teachers and trainers, and sensitizing enterprises.

Greening Technical Vocational Education Training and skills development: A practical guidance tool | International Labour Organization

Other sources

De Groene Draad: https://lerenvoormorgen.org/artikelen/de-groene-draad/ (in Dutch only)
The Green Thread is a tool in the Dutch language developed by representatives from Dutch VET schools and green skills experts supported by CINOP and aims to provide teaching teams with practical tools for future-oriented educational development. The steps outlined in the Service Document enable teams to build an integrated 'green thread' into their vocational education programmemes in their own way and at their own pace.
The service document is accompanied by a toolbox that contains:

- The steps from the service document, broken down into actions.
- Background information.
- Working materials such as templates
- Sources of inspiration such as examples, sustainability experts, training, etc.

Brookings approaches to education for climate action
A new green learning agenda: Approaches to quality education for climate action | Brookings
A paper from the Brookings Center for Universal Education presenting that provides climate and education decisionmakers with: 1) a framework for conceptualizing the green
skills needed to catalyze both technical and social transformation and 2) a tool for considering three approaches to quality education for climate action.

Training Manual Greening TVET (Colombo Plan Staff College for HRD in Asia and Pacific Region)
Training Manual on Greening TVET